

with GDP growth of 7 per cent and higher. That has never happened before. It is a true inflection point. And it is an inflection point from a demographic point of view, from an economic point of view, and it has to be an inflection point for technology companies. We have to start thinking different. So we know that 500 million people will be urbanised in the next five years; five New Yorks will be built a year in this part of the world. How can we use technology to build these smart cities? We see a tremendous middle-class and that middle-class will create buying power with the scaling capability and sometimes I think you don't even realise you are sitting in the middle of it. And when I look and I talk to, for instance, ICICI and when they say we are going to add 60 million new customers in the next two years, then I think this is the entire population of France; that is the entire population of Turkey and they are going to add it in two years.

Speakers with session chairperson Sanjoy Narayan (right)



RAVI S SAHNI

“OUR MISSION IS TO MAKE A TECHNOLOGY COMPANY THAT CAN CHANGE THE WAY WE WORK AND LEARN.”

Wim Elfrink

When you talk about adding 10 million new phone subscribers a month, you know it is half the population of the country I come from and you add it in a month. So that is going to lead to scaling, innovation, and new ways of looking at businesses. And, mobility will be a platform as that is going to change the way people live, play, learn and work.

Our mission is to get the innovation, the scaling, to learn to get there and see how we can make a technology company that can change the way we work, play, live and learn. But it is the leadership which has to drive that. I want to give you examples of transformational opportunities from a technology point of view. Take telepresence. It is going to be pervasive, at the moment it is in boardrooms. But look at the medical applications by which you do telemedicine. The quality is so good that you can look at the skin colour, you can look in the pupils of the patient. It is going to change the way medical care is handled in rural areas. We have to meet

the price points. Don't get me wrong, we will learn that here in India.

So thinking transformational point of view, our technology can enable new business models. We are used to and we are educated to think about water, electricity, and transportation. Now think about connectivity as a complete new utility as it can enhance your business plans and think about the transformational opportunities it creates for your country.

D I S C U S S I O N

Q. Mr. Elfrink, you are the chief globalisation officer in Cisco. Why did you choose to base yourself in India and not anywhere else?

Elfrink: We do more business in China than we do in India at the moment but India is very export-oriented. Information and communication technology is an export product in India. And we see India as the basis for globalisation. Cooperative governments in democracy, well educated and talented young people, a nation based on diversity and growth, culture and history create unprecedented opportunities in addition to advantages arising out of geographical proximity to a major chunk of the world population. With a five-hour flight out of India, you can reach 70 per cent of the world population. India also has the

potential of protection of intellectual property rights which makes it an easy choice.

Q. What are you doing to the wastage that comes off the electronic handsets, computers? Are there some initiatives being taken by your companies into the research of taking care of this waste management?

Mittal: We are still not at a point where we are generating that much of garbage because of reuse in India. But yes, we are coming to a point where it is going to be a serious problem specially with all the chemicals on the printed circuit boards and all the electronic components which go in there. They are going to create a lot of hazardous waste out there in the market place. Only those equipment that are with us are being managed when we dispose them off. But the hundreds of

millions of devices in the market place are not in our reach. But collectively, the country will need to take care of proper waste management.

Elfrink: I would say three things to take care of this. First do R&D to reduce power consumption, use better materials. That is a company initiative and a green initiative in general. Second, recycle—see whether we can reuse what we have discarded. Third, look at different ways of doing business.

Q. You mentioned regulatory hurdle which will delay your transgression, as you called it, into banking. What are the other hurdles and how do you plan to anticipate and tackle them?

Mittal: I try to look at the final positions in hours and hurdles. Yes, I would never want to be regulated by one more regulator, having been

regulated by one is enough and RBI, oh my God! never.

The vision that you saw here predicates very heavily on broadband and it can be delivered in two ways. You can either physically wire the country or you can provide it through the air. I don't think we are going to get to a point where we will wire this country anymore. We need to put out 3G services into the country. And the technology exists, the price points are great, affordability is there. I hope that this last pasture on which the government is still debating, after which about six-eight months later, you will see broadband services. We are two years late. Can't afford any more delays. That is the biggest challenge in front of the industry today.

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